

Altec Lansing inMotion iM600 iPods On The Move



Altec Lansing's inMotion iM600 is an iPod dock that doubles as a radio and speaker for your PC or any other MP3 player.

The dock itself is stylish and compact, and is a small rectangular block but can be unfolded on a table. All the iPod models can be docked, including the latest iPod Touch. You can charge your iPod or synchronise your music as well.

There are controls for volume adjustment at the

base of the dock and the track switching buttons on the top. The volume control buttons are hard and tacky, whereas the smaller track controlling buttons are very soft and tiny. There does not seem to be any button for pausing or stopping tracks. Other than that, the dock is simple to use and comes with an inbuilt display on the front, which shows the source of the track and volume control. There's also a compact little remote con-

trol, like those found on many of their desktop speakers sets.

The iM600 has good music quality, but it lacks bass in the tracks due to its flat design. It is loud though, and there is little or no distortion with the volume set to maximum. The SFX button doesn't really do a whole lot other than making the sound slightly better.

The dock comes with an auxiliary connector, which means you can connect any other iPod MP3 player to it, or even your computer for that matter. You also can use it as an FM radio, and the antenna comes well tucked into the back of the dock. One of the biggest plus points of this product is the inbuilt chargeable Li-ion battery that charges itself when powered on. This dock is then mobile but docking an iPod in a moving vehicle might not

be a good idea—the base plug could damage itself or the iPod connector from the vibrations.

The Altec Lansing iM600 is priced at Rs 7,500. It's a tad costlier than we'd like it to be, but the functionality, flexibility and performance that it offers is hard to come by in such a product, especially in the Indian market.

Specifications:

Dimensions: 28.3 x 4.3 x 15.2 cm (Folded), Weight: 0.9 kgs, Battery capacity: 2150 mAh

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★
Features	★★★★
Build quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★
Overall	★★★★

Contact: Rashi Peripherals Pvt. Ltd.

Phone: 022-67090909

E-mail: altec@rpotechindia.com

Web site: www.alteclansing.com

Price: Rs 7,500

Belkin N1 Vision Bringing Style To Routers

Belkin has entered the Indian market with one of their first products—the N1 Vision router. It might be a utility, but Belkin has managed to make it look like a lifestyle product.

The design is very good and stands out amongst all the routers you might come across today. Unlike most routers, the N1 stands vertically, but the stand is stable and has rubber padding at the base to stop it from sliding around. There is a small screen on the front, which shows data speeds of all the users connected to the router, both wired and wirelessly. There are buttons that can be used to navigate through the interface and the display can also be used as a clock as well.

When it comes to performance, it works pretty well on the wired ports. We recorded speeds of 7.36 Mbps for a single large file. For random files, the speeds were around 6.92 Mbps. The wireless tests revealed the weakness of the N1 Vision. The wireless performance was pretty appalling—2Mbps is the best it could do over a distance of some 10 feet.

The software interface has all the features that a router firmware should have—Internet connectivity configuration, VPN, security, etc. The interface is more user-friendly than those on most well known routers. One thing you notice is the long waiting period for the router to restart every time you change a setting.



The price for the Belkin N1 Vision—Rs 11,699—is much higher than mainstream home routers. Although this router will look nice in your living room, it's definitely not something you can rely on for performance.

Specifications:

IEEE 802.11g / b / n compatible, Security: WPA / WPA2, 64 / 128-bit WEP encryption, multiple SSID, VPN Support: PPTP, IPSec



pass-through, One WAN port, 4 gigabit ports.

Contact: Belkin

Phone: 000-800-440-1406

E-mail: madhuj@belkin.com

Web site: www.belkin.com

Price: Rs 11,699

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★
Features	★★★★
Build quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★
Overall	★★★

Canon PowerShot A720 IS Incremental Update

The Canon PowerShot A720 IS is an upgrade to the A710 IS, which was a very good point-and-shoot camera—one of the best that we saw during our comparison test last year. The most prominent change in the A720 IS, is its resolution. It is now an 8 Megapixel camera as opposed to the 7.1 MP A710.

The picture quality has stayed pretty much the same too. The ISO level on this camera goes up to 1600. The A710 IS had a maximum of 800. The amount of grain beyond 800 is pretty bad and should be avoided as far as possible. The zoom lens is decent and there's no serious degradation of quality at maximum zoom.

The colours—as with all other Canons—are very neutral and not exaggerated. The images aren't too high on

contrast so there's a smooth balance between the dark and the bright areas. This makes for some good portrait photography. The flash is pretty powerful too and the slow sync mode works rather well in illuminating the background in shots with the flash on. Macro shots are fairly easy to shoot and it's possible to get extremely close to the object. The A720 IS now has a face detection feature, which works well and tracks people through darker areas as well.

The movie quality is decent and actually usable in low light situations. There're no sudden jumps in exposure while moving from bright areas to dark ones. Image stabilization evens out the bumps and the zoom works well, although a little aggressively, in the movie shooting mode.



Sensitivity: 80–1600, Shutter speed 1/2000th–15 seconds, Aperture range—f2.8–f4.8, Movie recording: 640x480 at 30 fps, 2.5-inch screen.

The A720 IS, is incrementally superior to the A710 IS. The problem with the A720 IS, is not so much to do with the camera itself, but with the other cameras even from Canon itself in the same price bracket. The SX100 is more or less available for the same price in the market and comes with a 10X optical zoom. If any, the A720 IS's only advantage is that of being a little more compact than the SX100 IS.

Specifications:

8.0 MP, 4x optical zoom, ISO

Contact: Canon India Private Limited

Phone: 1800-345-33-66

E-mail: info@canon.co.in

Web site: www.canon.co.in

Price: Rs 14,995

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★
Features	★★★★
Build quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★
Overall	★★★★

Audioengine A2 Affordable Audiophilia Inducer

Audioengine is a comparatively new brand and is fairly unheard of to many. The Audioengine A2s are the less powerful versions of the larger A5s.

They are small when compared with computer speakers available these days but the build quality is just unmatched. They are made of wood cabinets with a smooth glossy finish. They have heavy and gold-plated connectors. Quality is maintained everywhere—even the well shielded cables are some of the best we've seen. The only problem with the design is the volume knob which is situated at the back of the speakers which means you need to move to the back of the speakers.

When it comes to performance, these small speakers go ballistic—espe-

cially for their size. They're not as powerful as Altec Lansing's MX5021, but for their size, they are highly impressive and can get really loud without losing any clarity. There are vents at the bottom of the speaker, which breathe out loads of air when played at decent volumes. The power isn't even its forte. It delivers great detail and very neutral tone, without any exaggerated highs or lows.

At first, they sound a little muddy without any sparkling highs. Speakers like this require some burn-in period and some improvement in the quality and vibrancy could be noticed after a few days time.

The solidly built A2s come in two colours—black and white and in a neat package with soft cloth



pouches for each speaker. At a price of Rs 10,400, although excellent, it's a little difficult to recommend these speakers to everyone. These speakers are great for music, but not so much for movies mainly because of the lacking bass-woofer. For people who are used to listening to music with loads of bass, this definitely will be an unfulfilling experience. However, if it's detail, clarity and good tone you appreciate, the Audioengine A2 is undoubtedly among the best desktop speaker sets you can find in this price range.

Specifications:

30W RMS (each speaker 15 W), Inputs: 2 RCA inputs and 3.5-mm mini-jack, built-in power amp, Dimensions: 6 x 4 x 5.25 inches

Contact: Audio Products India Phone: +91 9324233508

E-mail: audioenginesales@gmail.com

Web site: www.audioengine-usa.com

Price: Rs 10,400

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★
Features	★★★★
Build quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★
Overall	★★★★